

01.2 Eligibility Criteria

Inclusion categories, exclusion codes, and decision rules

This document defines the eligibility criteria for the scoping review. Studies were first assessed against exclusion criteria, then classified into one of four inclusion categories by study design and evidence contribution.

1. Inclusion Criteria: Study Classification System

Eligible studies were classified into four categories by design, data type, and evidence contribution. The categories distinguish studies supporting causal inference from those describing naturally occurring patterns, interpreting experiences, or characterising policy provision. Tool-level rather than study-level synthesis follows evidence-mapping methodology (Miake-Lye et al., 2016).

Primary classification question. *Did the researchers deliberately manipulate or deliver the RG tool with a comparison condition?*

Table 01.2.1 *Study Category Classification Overview*

Category	Definition	Causal inference	Evidence contribution
EXP [EFFECTIVENESS]	Experimental or quasi-experimental studies testing RG tool effects with comparison condition	Permitted	Effectiveness
OBS [QUANTITATIVE – REACH]	Quantitative examination of naturally occurring RG tool use without manipulation	Not permitted	Reach
QUAL [REACH – IMPLEMENTATION]	Interpretive exploration of meanings, experiences, and processes related to RG tools	Not applicable	Reach, Implementation
POL [POLICY – IMPLEMENTATION]	Studies of regulatory requirements, compliance, or industry-level RG provision	Limited	Adoption, Implementation

1.1 Experimental Studies (EXP)

- **Definition.** Experimental or quasi-experimental studies that deliberately test the effects of an RG tool compared to a control or comparison condition.
- **Designs included.** Randomised controlled trials (RCTs), cluster randomised trials, quasi-experimental designs with comparison groups, within-subjects experimental designs with counterbalancing, laboratory analogue studies with random assignment, discrete choice experiments, and multiple baseline designs.
- **Inclusion indicators.** “Randomised,” “randomly assigned,” “control group,” “comparison condition,” “experimental,” “between-subjects,” “within-subjects,” “we tested whether,” “compared X to Y.”
- **Language mode.** Causal language permitted: “reduced,” “caused,” “led to,” “resulted in,” “significantly lower than control.” Effect sizes reported (d, η^2 , OR, RR).
- **Boundary rules.** Lab studies with random assignment are classified as EXP even with simulated gambling or student samples. Pre-post designs without control group are classified as OBS, not EXP.

1.2 Observational Quantitative Studies (OBS)

- **Definition.** Studies that quantitatively examine naturally occurring RG tool use, player preferences, behavioural patterns, or outcomes without experimental manipulation.
- **Designs included.** Analysis of operator transaction and tracking data, cross-sectional surveys with quantitative outcomes, longitudinal observational cohorts, pre-post designs without control group, secondary analysis of administrative data, predictive modelling studies, and psychometric validation studies of deployed player-facing tools.

- **Inclusion indicators.** “Transaction data,” “player tracking,” “account records,” “survey,” “questionnaire,” “cross-sectional,” “prevalence,” “uptake,” “attitudes toward.”
- **Language mode.** Associational language only: “showed,” “was associated with,” “were characterised by,” “X% activated.” Never state the tool “reduced” or “caused” outcomes.
- **Boundary rules.** Analysis of naturally occurring limit users is OBS due to self-selection. Surveys asking preferences (not efficacy) are OBS.

1.3 Qualitative Studies (QUAL)

- **Definition.** Studies that explore meanings, experiences, perceptions, and processes related to RG tools using interpretive methods.
- **Designs included.** Semi-structured interviews, focus groups, ethnographic observation, narrative analysis, open-ended survey responses analysed thematically, think-aloud protocols, and grounded theory studies.
- **Inclusion indicators.** “Qualitative,” “interviews,” “focus groups,” “thematic analysis,” “grounded theory,” “phenomenological,” “experiences of,” “themes included.”
- **Language mode.** Interpretive language: “participants described,” “a key theme was,” “users reported experiencing,” “barriers included.”

1.4 Policy and Implementation Studies (POL)

- **Definition.** Studies examining regulatory requirements, policy implementation, operator compliance, or industry-level RG tool provision.
- **Designs included.** Systematic website or venue assessments, regulatory compliance audits, policy document analysis, cross-jurisdictional comparative studies, natural experiments examining policy changes, and implementation fidelity evaluations.
- **Inclusion indicators.** “Policy,” “regulation,” “compliance audit,” “website assessment,” “X% of operators,” “licensing requirements,” “code of conduct.”
- **Language mode.** Compliance and descriptive language: “X% provided,” “compliance was,” “regulation requires,” “gap between policy and practice.”

2. Exclusion Criteria: Hierarchical Code System

Exclusion criteria were applied hierarchically. Once a study met a criterion, it was assigned that code and not evaluated against subsequent criteria. This prevented ambiguity when studies met multiple criteria.

Table 01.2.2 Summary of Exclusion Criteria Codes

Level	Domain	Codes	Description
1	Publication type	EXCL-PUBTYPE-*	Document format exclusions (opinions, protocols, books, etc.)
2	Language	EXCL-LANG	Non-English language publications
3	Topic	EXCL-TOPIC-*	Subject matter outside scope (other addictions, finance, etc.)
4	Context	EXCL-CONTEXT-*	Setting or circumstance exclusions (COVID, unique jurisdictions)
5	Population	EXCL-POP-*	Sample characteristic exclusions (specific subgroups, youth)
6	Relevance	EXCL-REL-*	RG tool focus exclusions (descriptive, mechanism, method)

2.1 Level 1: Publication Type (EXCL-PUBTYPE)

Applied first to filter non-empirical or inaccessible documents before content evaluation.

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-PUBTYPE-OPINION	Editorials, commentaries, letters to editor, and opinion pieces without empirical data	Commentary on RG policy; letter responding to published study
EXCL-PUBTYPE-PROTOCOL	Study protocols, registered reports, and pre-registrations describing planned research	Trial registration; systematic review protocol
EXCL-PUBTYPE-BOOK	Book chapters, monographs, and edited volumes not available as peer-reviewed articles	Handbook chapter on gambling; edited collection
EXCL-PUBTYPE-CONF	Conference abstracts and proceedings not published as full peer-reviewed papers	EASG conference abstract; poster presentation
EXCL-PUBTYPE-DISSERT	Theses and dissertations not published as peer-reviewed articles	PhD dissertation; Masters thesis
EXCL-PUBTYPE-UNAVAILABLE	Full text not obtainable through institutional access, interlibrary loan, or author contact	Article behind paywall with no alternative access

2.2 Level 2: Language (EXCL-LANG)

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-LANG	Publications not available in English, including those with English abstracts but non-English full text	German-language journal article; French report with English summary only

2.3 Level 3: Topic (EXCL-TOPIC)

Applied to exclude studies whose primary focus falls outside the scope of responsible gambling tools.

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-TOPIC-OTHADD	Primary focus on other addictions (substance use, gaming disorder, internet addiction) rather than gambling	Alcohol intervention; video game addiction treatment; internet use disorder
EXCL-TOPIC-OFFTOPIC	Subject matter unrelated to gambling or RG tools	General mental health; unrelated public health; non-gambling consumer protection
EXCL-TOPIC-THIRDPARTY	Focus on affected others (family members, partners) rather than gamblers themselves	Family therapy for gambling; partner support programmes; children of gamblers
EXCL-TOPIC-MH	Primary focus on comorbid mental health conditions rather than gambling-specific interventions	Depression treatment in gamblers; anxiety intervention; PTSD treatment
EXCL-TOPIC-FINANCE	Focus on financial products, services, or literacy without gambling-specific RG tools	General financial counselling; debt management; credit interventions
EXCL-TOPIC-PHARM	Pharmacological interventions for gambling disorder	Naltrexone trials; opioid antagonists; medication studies
EXCL-TOPIC-TECH	Technology development, algorithmic and AI work, and risk detection studies reporting only model performance without evaluation of player-facing outcomes or RG tool deployment	AI development without RG application; pure computer science; risk detection model papers reporting only accuracy or AUC metrics without deployment in a player-facing tool
EXCL-TOPIC-NONHUMAN	Animal studies or non-human research	Rodent gambling models; primate studies

2.4 Level 4: Context (EXCL-CONTEXT)

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-CONTEXT-COVID	Studies primarily examining COVID-19 pandemic effects on gambling rather than RG tools	Pandemic gambling behaviour changes; lockdown effects on gambling
EXCL-CONTEXT-GEO-NONWEST	Studies from non-Western gambling contexts where RG frameworks differ substantially	Gambling in contexts without established RG regulatory frameworks
EXCL-CONTEXT-GEO-UNIQUE	Jurisdiction-specific studies with limited generalisability to other contexts	Highly localised regulatory analysis; single-venue case studies

2.5 Level 5: Population (EXCL-POP)

Note. General student samples are NOT excluded when testing RG tools. Only specific subgroups with unique characteristics are excluded.

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-POP-SUBGROUP	Studies focusing on specific population subgroups whose characteristics limit generalisability to general gambling populations	College athletes; military veterans; incarcerated populations; professional poker players
EXCL-POP-YOUTH	Studies focusing exclusively on minors or underage gambling prevention	Adolescent gambling prevention; school-based programmes for under-18s

2.6 Level 6: Relevance (EXCL-REL)

Applied at full-text review to exclude studies that, despite being gambling-related, do not examine RG tools.

Code	Definition	Examples
EXCL-REL-DESC	Descriptive studies of gambling behaviour, prevalence, or patterns without RG tool focus	Gambling participation surveys; expenditure patterns; demographic profiles of gamblers
EXCL-REL-MECH	Studies examining psychological or behavioural mechanisms without RG tool evaluation	Cognitive distortions; impulsivity; near-miss effects; illusion of control; tilt mechanisms
EXCL-REL-METHOD	Methodological papers developing instruments not specifically for RG purposes	General gambling screens; motivation scales; typology development without RG application; psychometric validation of instruments not evaluated as deployed player-facing tools

3. Classification Decision Rules**Table 01.2.3***Decision Rules for Ambiguous Cases*

Scenario	Classification	Rationale
Pre-post design without control group	OBS	No causal inference possible without comparison
Lab study with random assignment	EXP	Experimental manipulation present, even with simulated gambling
Student sample testing RG tool	EXP (if experimental)	Sample type does not determine category; design does
Analysis of naturally occurring limit users	OBS	Self-selection into tool use precludes causal inference
Survey asking ‘would you use X?’	OBS	Measuring preferences, not efficacy
Interview asking ‘how did you experience X?’	QUAL	Interpretive exploration of experiences
Mixed methods (survey + interviews)	Dominant component OR separate extractions	Classify by primary contribution
Delphi survey with expert ratings	OBS	Quantitative aggregation of expert judgement
Website audit of RG features	POL	Focus on operator provision, not individual outcomes

Note. RG = responsible gambling. Studies were evaluated against exclusion criteria hierarchically (Levels 1–6); those not excluded were classified into one of four inclusion categories (EXP, OBS, QUAL, POL) by design. The EXCL-* prefix here refers to screening exclusion codes. The same prefix appears in 02.3 with a different meaning (EXCL-LONG, EXCL-TEMP); the two code spaces are namespace-distinct.